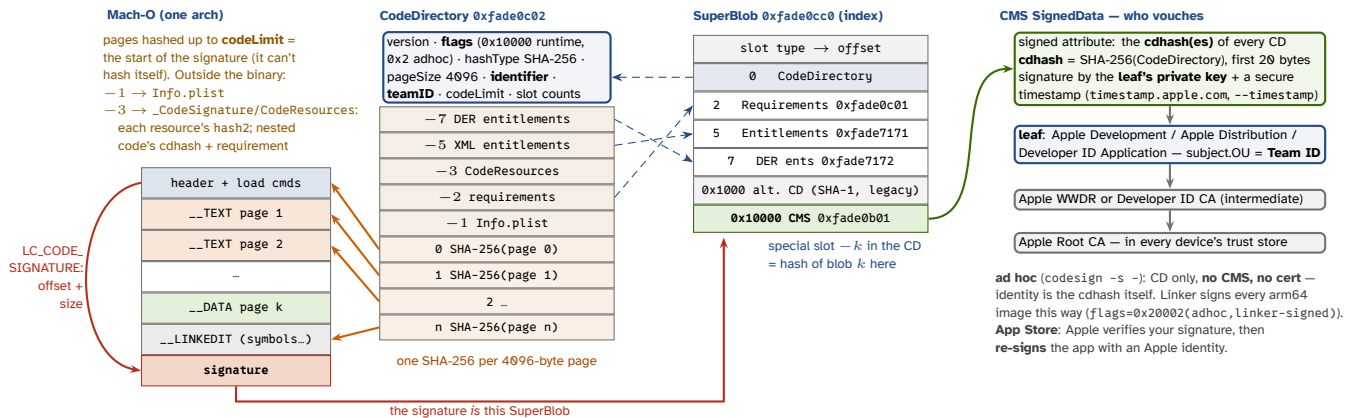


In one line: A signature is a **SuperBlob** appended to `__LINKEDIT` and located by `LC_CODE_SIGNATURE`. Its heart is the **CodeDirectory**: a SHA-256 hash of every **4 KiB page** of the file (code slots) plus hashes of **Info.plist, requirements, resources and entitlements** (special slots). The hash of the CodeDirectory — the **cdhash** — is what a **CMS** signature from your certificate signs, so one signature covers every byte; the kernel re-hashes each page as it is **paged in**.



Signing

- codesign hashes the file in **4096-byte pages** up to **codeLimit**, writes the CD, requirements and entitlements, then the CMS over the cdhash. Universal binary: **one signature per arch**, different cdhashes (--arch arm64).
- Hash agility:** macOS ≤ 10.11 needed a SHA-1 CD too (0x1000 alternate slot); since 10.12 a single SHA-256 CD. CodeDirectory v=20500 ... hashes=14+7 = 14 code pages + 7 special slots.
- Entitlements** are signed in twice: XML plist (slot 5/—5) and DER (7/—7, the format the OS parses; required on iOS 15+ (unverified)). Old signatures without DER must be re-signed; App Store builds already are.
- Bundles:** Info.plist and resources are outside the Mach-O, so they are **sealed** by hash — edit one PNG and the seal breaks ("a sealed resource is missing or invalid").
- Nested code signs inside-out:** dylibs/frameworks → XPC services, app extensions, helpers → the app **last**, because the outer seal records each inner cdhash. Sign the app first and any inner re-sign invalidates it. Xcode does the order; by hand never sign with --deep (it pushes one set of entitlements/options onto everything) — --deep is for **verify** only.
- Code must sit where code belongs (Frameworks/, MacOS/, PlugIns/); a Mach-O in Resources/ is sealed as data, not signed as code.

Requirements — the code's identity (macOS)

A **requirement** is a boolean expression over a signature; the **designated requirement (DR)** says "if you see me again, this is how you know it's me". TCC grants, keychain ACLs and XPC peers (setCodeSigningRequirement) store the DR, not a hash — that's how v1.3 inherits v1.2's microphone permission.

```
designated => identifier "com.example.app" and anchor apple generic
and certificate leaf[subject.OU] = "ABCDE12345" # team
anchor apple and identifier "com.apple.TextEdit" # Apple's own
cdhash H"ff19a91b..." # this exact build only - brittle
```

Example — reading and making a signature

```
codesign -dvuv App.app # CDHash, Authority chain, TeamIdentifier
codesign -d -vvvvuv App.app # + every slot hash (page size 4096)
codesign -d --entitlements - App.app # raw XML ("bplist00" = broken)
codesign -d -f App.app # designated => ...
codesign --verify --deep --strict -vvv App.app # notarization-grade check
codesign -v -R \
  -anchor apple generic and identifier "com.example.app" App.app
codesign -s -f tool # ad hoc re-sign (after lipo/patch)
codesign -s "Developer ID Application: Alice (ABCDE12345)" \
  -o runtime --timestamp --entitlements app.entitlements -f App.app
```

How it is enforced

- At exec / mmap:** the kernel loads the blob, checks each CD hash against the CMS' cdhash list; **AMFI** (AppleMobileFileIntegrity) decides if the signer may run this: platform binaries by cdhash in the **trust cache**, third-party code by certificate + provisioning profile (entitlements ⊆ profile) via amfid.
- At page-in:** every page faulted in from a signed file is hashed and compared to its code slot. Mismatch + CS_KILL → **SIGKILL** (crash "CODESIGNING" (unverified)). Lazy: a tampered page that never runs is never noticed.
- Process flags** (cs_blobs.h): CS_VALID 0x1 · CS_ADHOC 0x2 · CS_GET_TASK_ALLOW 0x4 · CS_HARD 0x100 (refuse invalid pages) · CS_KILL 0x200 · CS_REQUIRE_LV 0x2000 (library validation) · CS_RUNTIME 0x10000 (hardened runtime) · CS_LINKER_SIGNED 0x20000.
- Apple silicon:** macOS won't run **unsigned** arm64 code at all — ad hoc is enough to run, not to distribute (Gatekeeper wants Developer ID + notarization). Intel could run unsigned. Patch a byte in a binary → killed at launch.
- Team ID** (in the CD and the leaf's OU) drives library validation and keychain/app-group scoping.

Traps

- ! "The signature encrypts the app" — no: it **hashes and signs**; FairPlay (cryptid) is the encryption.
- ! codesign --deep to **sign** — wrong entitlements on nested code; sign inside-out.
- ! Editing Info.plist / a resource after signing breaks the seal.
- ! A fresh ad hoc build changes cdhash → TCC/keychain ask again: the DR is the cdhash.
- ! lipo/install_name_tool/strip after signing breaks it — re-sign last.

Remember

"Pages → CodeDirectory → cdhash → CMS → Team cert → Apple root — and the kernel re-checks each page as it faults in."